

THE REVOLUTIONISTS
The Story of the Extremists Who Hijacked the 1970s
By Jason Burke
PENGUIN/THE BODLEY HEAD
₹1,099; 448 pages

NON-FICTION ▼

The Age of Terror

JASON BURKE'S *THE REVOLUTIONISTS* CHARTS THE DARK JOURNEY OF GLOBAL TERRORISM WITH THE PACE OF A THRILLER AND THE DEPTH OF SERIOUS HISTORY

Jason Burke begins his story in an age of innocence, when terrorists simply walked across the tarmac to board commercial flights unchecked, with guns and bombs in their hand baggage. *The Revolutionists* then traces the evolution of increasingly sanguinary terrorism into the early 1980s, with the transformation of 'secular, leftist' terrorists into the movements of jihad that dominate terrorism even today. Drawing on three decades of front-line reporting, declassified files, and interviews with hijackers, counter-terrorism agents, spies and survivors, Burke crafts a narrative that is as compulsive as a thriller, even as he retains exceptional rigour in argument and documentation.

The Revolutionists is no mere chronicle, as Burke refuses to flatten his subjects into stereotypes. He probes the human frailties behind revolutionary and radical postures: the functional illiteracy of some 'ideologues', paranoia, love and betrayal, the thrill of camaraderie amid carnage, idiosyncrasies of personality, the thirst for adventure, and outsize egos. We meet the 'grenade girl' Leila Khaled; Carlos 'the Jackal', the 'Leftist mastermind' with a taste for luxurious living, whose reputation far exceeds his actual exploits; shadowy double agents who navigate the treacherous alliances between Baader-Meinhof militants and PLO factions; "strikingly beautiful with her fine features and long dark hair" Fusako Shigenobu, plotting mass murder; the fireball assassination of Fatah's top killer, Ali Hasan Salameh; and the early years of a trepidatious Osama bin Laden...

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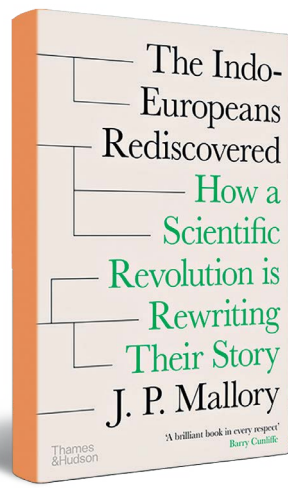
Burke handles the rise of Islamism with nuance, neither demonising the faith nor excusing its weaponisation, a balance that is especially vital in the polarised discourse of our age. The book also reconstructs decisive terrorist and counter-terrorist operations, with which we believe ourselves familiar, but rediscover in startling detail. The spectacular Entebbe Raid that forced terrorists and supporting states to rewrite the entire hijacking playbook; the Munich Massacre, which grabbed spectacular global attention and provoked a relentless Israeli campaign of vengeance; the Beirut Bombings, which became the base of future jihadi movements; the farcical and bloody Iranian Embassy Siege in London, which ends badly for a group of inept terrorists, in a "spectacular denouement" covered live by BBC; and many more.

At around 450 pages, *The Revolutionists* initially appears daunting, but its riveting narrative and compelling subject quickly draw you in, and forward. A great read for anyone interested in the origins of the radicalism and globalised violence that plague us today. ■

—Ajai Sahni

I want to reflect on four books that made a major impact on me in 2025; what all four share is a focus on the history of people, their practices and their folkways, not the dry recitation of battles and the rise and fall of kings.

Laura Spinney's *Proto* is about the reconstruction of a lost language, the common ancestor of all Indo-European languages, spoken by about half of the world's people, but in the course of the narrative you survey fields as disparate as comparative linguistics, archaeology and the politics of



THE INDO-EUROPEANS REDISCOVERED How a Scientific Revolution is Rewriting Their Story
By J.P. Mallory
THAMES & HUDSON
£35; 448 pages